



the referee halts a fight before its natural conclusion due to concerns for the safety of one or both fighters.

Anshul also protested inside the ring immediately after the decision was announced.

Fellow lightweight fighter Renato Moicano, ranked 10th in the division, was the first to put out a critical take on the fight. “20 years to have an Indian in UFC, and the referee does that,” read his post on the social media platform X.

Similarly, bantamweight titleholder Merab Dvalishvili said, “It was early. Early stoppage,” in featherweight champion Ilia Topuria’s *Instagram* live video.

Anshul posted a video on his social media handle shortly after the fight, echoing the sentiments of Moicano and Dvalishvili.

“I believe that was an early stoppage. Yes, I was hit by a good shot and dropped, but I was defending myself smartly even as I

Heartbreak: Anshul protested the decision inside the ring immediately after the decision was announced, as Salkild celebrated the contentious win. Pics: GETTY IMAGES

fell,” he said.

Social media discourse aside had Anshul not let his guard down, Salkild wouldn’t have found the opening to capitalise.

But Indian MMA fans have something to look forward to in the UFC circuit. Puja Tomar will travel to London on March 23 to face fellow newcomer Shauna Bannon of Ireland.

‘Stillknocks’ is still the king

Dricus Du Plessis (**below, right**) defended his middleweight belt with a dominant unanimous decision victory over a bloodied Sean Strickland (**below, left**) at UFC 312.

Since his UFC debut in 2020, this is only the third time a fight involving Du Plessis has gone the full distance — whether three or five rounds — including the first time he was crowned champion in 2022. Interestingly, he had defeated the same opponent back then via split decision, although this time, he barely broke a sweat.

The earlier rounds belonged to Du Plessis, as his low kicks took a toll on

Strickland’s legs, while the American used his jab in an attempt to find a chink in the South African’s defence.

The pivotal moment in an otherwise laid-back fight occurred early in the fourth round when a powerful right hand from the South African connected with Strickland’s defences, breaking the American’s nose.

With blood flowing profusely from his nose, Strickland attempted to survive the round without sustaining any further devastating blows, but Du Plessis pressed forward, seeking a stoppage. Strickland managed to last until the bell, but the damage was significant, and Du Plessis did enough in the final round to ensure a comfortable victory. This marked his second successful title defence, following his fourth-round submission victory over Israel Adesanya in August in Perth, Australia.

In the co-main event, China’s Zhang Weili retained her strawweight championship with a unanimous decision victory over the No. 1-ranked Tatiana Suarez.

Zhang dominated the fight, while Suarez struggled with a deep knee cut from the octagon fence.

With four straight title defences — three by unanimous decision and one by submission — Zhang’s reign remains unchallenged.

